Within the fort, one man seemed especially miserable. Every evening when the troops were at dinner, General Sale would slip off ‘ostensibly to have a quiet look around at the progress of our work’, wrote Thomas Seaton, ‘but in reality to ponder on the desperate situation of his wife and daughter, and to debate with himself the possibility of effecting their rescue’. Seaton realised that, now that the siege was over and its anxieties passed, Sale’s thoughts were dwelling more and more on the fate of his family, especially now that Ellenborough seemed to be contemplating withdrawing from Afghanistan and leaving the prisoners of war and the hostages in captivity. There were also the rumours which had been circulating during the siege that Akbar might bring Lady Sale before the walls of the city and torture her within Sale’s sight, so compelling him to surrender. One evening Seaton found himself on guard duty as Sale did his lonely rounds, and he plucked up the courage to ask the General what he would do had such a report proved true: ‘Turning towards me, his face pale and stern, but quivering with deep emotion, he replied, “I-I will have every gun turned on her; my old bones shall be buried beneath the ruins of the fort here; but I shall never surrender.”’[19]

Sale’s defeat of Akbar Khan turned out to be a very mixed blessing for Lady Sale and her fellow hostages.

Like the Jalalabad garrison before them, they had heard the false rumours of Pollock’s defeat, and had been plunged into depression at the thought of their ever-lengthening captivity. But when news came through of Sale’s victory and Pollock’s successful passage through the Khyber it brought with it a period of renewed uncertainty. After eleven weeks of stability, they were ordered back on to their horses and sent off northwards, away from any attempts that the British might make to rescue them. They later learned that after the Battle of Jalalabad many of the chiefs – especially those of the eastern Ghilzai – had demanded that they be put to death. Only Akbar Khan’s personal intervention had saved them.[20]

Before they left on their wanderings, the pick of their goods were plundered by their jailer, Akbar’s father-in-law Mohammad Shah Khan, chief of the Babrkhel Ghilzai of Laghmanat. Lady Sale reported that he ‘has taken away all of Lady Macnaghten’s jewels to the value of above a lakh of rupees; and her shawls, valued at between 30 and 40,000 rupees’. But Lady